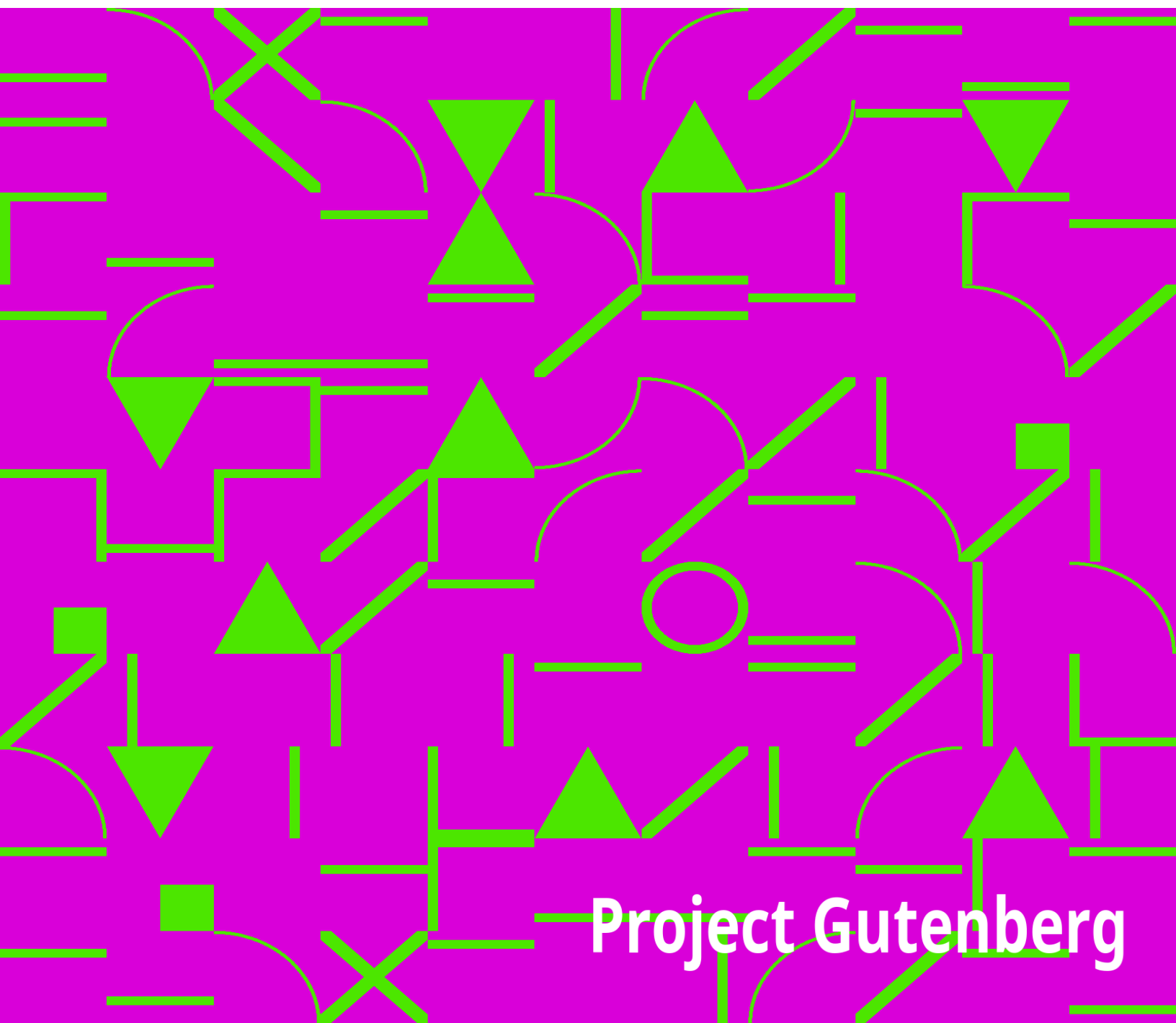


# Five Hundred Mistakes of Daily Occurrence in Speaking, Pronouncing, and Writing the English Language, Corrected

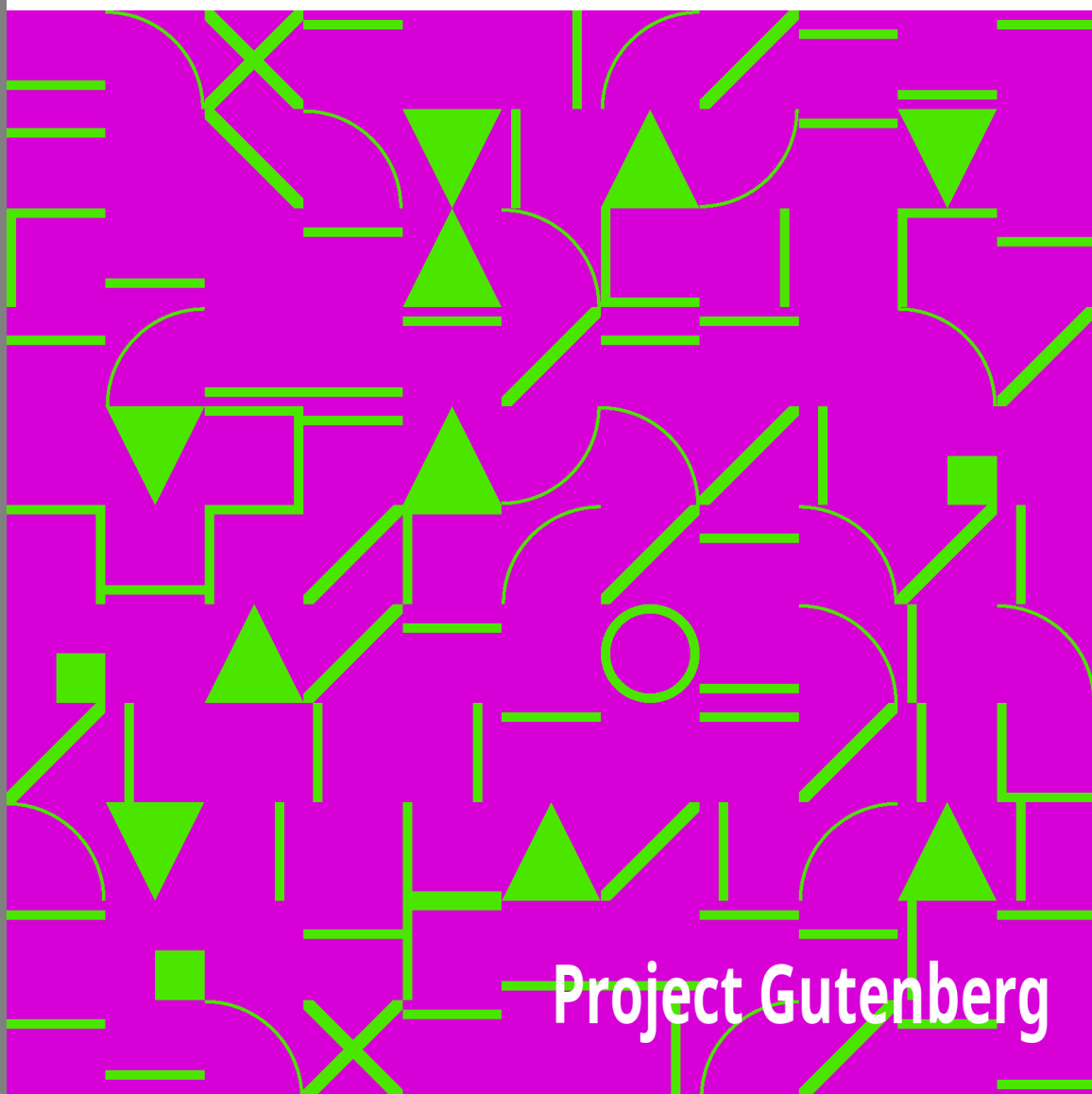
Walton Burgess



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# **The Project Gutenberg eBook of Five Hundred Mistakes of Daily Occurrence in Speaking, Pronouncing, and Writing the English Language, Corrected**

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Title: Five Hundred Mistakes of Daily Occurrence in Speaking, Pronouncing, and Writing the English Language, Corrected

Author: Walton Burgess

Release date: March 25, 2010 [eBook #31766]

Most recently updated: January 6, 2021

Language: English

Other information and formats: [www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/31766](http://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/31766)

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\*\*\* START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK FIVE HUNDRED  
MISTAKES OF DAILY OCCURRENCE IN SPEAKING,  
PRONOUNCING, AND WRITING THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE,  
CORRECTED \*\*\*

**“NEVER TOO LATE TO LEARN!”**

**FIVE HUNDRED MISTAKES**  
**OF DAILY OCCURRENCE**  
**IN SPEAKING, PRONOUNCING, AND WRITING**  
**THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE,**

## **CORRECTED.**

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“Which—if you but open—  
You will be unwilling,  
For many a shilling,  
To part with the profit  
Which you shall have of it.”

[*The Key to Unknown Knowledge*.—LONDON, 1569.]

“It is highly important, that whatever we learn or know, we should know  
CORRECTLY; for unless our knowledge be correct, we lose half its value and  
usefulness.”—*Conversations on Botany*.

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**NEW-YORK:**  
**DANIEL BURGESS & CO., 60 JOHN STREET.**  
**1856.**

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## PREFACE.

This book is offered to the public, not to be classed with elaborate or learned works, nor expected, like some of its more pretending companions among the offspring of the press, to run the gauntlet of literary criticism. It was prepared to meet the wants of persons—numbered by *multitudes* in even the most intelligent and refined communities—who from deficiency of education, or from carelessness of manner, are in the habit of misusing many of the most common words of the English language, distorting its grammatical forms, destroying its beauty, and corrupting its purity. The most thorough mode that could be adopted to correct such errors, would doubtless be to impart to the ignorant a practical knowledge of the principles of language, as embodied in treatises on grammar; but such a good work, however desirable its results, has, in time past, been too difficult for the promoters of education to complete, and is still too great to give promise of speedy accomplishment. A better expedient, bearing immediate fruits, has been adopted in the present volume, which, while it does not aim to produce a radical reform, cannot fail to render great service to those who need to improve their usual modes of expression, and to be more discriminating in their choice of words.

The more frequent and less excusable mistakes that may be noticed in ordinary conversation or correspondence, are here taken up, one by one—exposed, explained, and corrected. They consist variously of abuses of grammar, misapplications of words and phrases, improprieties of metaphor and comparison, misstatements of meaning, and faults of pronunciation. They are grouped miscellaneously, *without classification*, not so much because of the difficulty of devising an arrangement that would be systematic and intelligible, as from the evident fact that a division of subjects would render no assistance to those for whom the book is specially designed; for an appropriate classification would necessarily derive its features from the forms of grammar, and with these the readers of this book are supposed to be to a great extent unfamiliar.

The volume is put forth with no flourish of trumpets, and makes no extravagant pretensions; yet the publishers believe it will be regarded as a timely and useful work. If the race of *critics* should not like it—and while books have their “faults,” critics have their “failings”—they are reminded that he who corrects an old error, may render no less service to his brethren, than he who discovers a new truth. If the work shall be the means of saving one sensitive man from a confusion of blushes, in the presence of a company before which he desired to preserve his equanimity, it will not have gone forth without a mission of benefit, which will merit at least one acknowledgment.

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## INTRODUCTION.

The aim of this book, by correcting a multitude of common errors in the use of language, is mainly to offer assistance to such persons as need greater facilities for accurate expression *in ordinary conversation*. It is not designed to suggest topics of talk, nor to give rules or examples pointing out the proper modes of arranging them; but simply to insure persons who often have a good thing to say, from the confusion and mortification of improperly saying it. This chapter of introduction will not, therefore, be expected to present an essay on the general subject of conversation.

It may be remarked, however, by way of admonitory hint to some, that the most prominent error in the conversation of those who commit the most blunders, does not consist in saying too little that amounts to much, but too much that amounts to little; talkativeness is a characteristic more commonly of the ignorant, than of the wise. Shenstone says, “The common fluency of speech in many men, and most women, is owing to a scarcity of matter and a scarcity of words; for whoever is master of a language, and moreover has a mind full of ideas, will be apt, in speaking, to hesitate upon the choice of both; but common speakers have only one set of ideas and one set of words to clothe them in,—and these are always ready at the mouth. Just so, *people can come faster out of a church when it is almost empty, than when a crowd is at the door!*” But although, according to the old proverb, “a still tongue denotes a wise head,” the faculty of speech should not be neglected, merely because it may be misused.

Conversation is not a gift bestowed only upon those whom genius favors; on the contrary, many men eminent for their fluency of style in writing, have been noted for habitual taciturnity in their intercourse with society. Hazlitt remarked, that “authors should be read, not heard!” Charles II. of England, not only the wittiest of monarchs, but one of the liveliest of men, is said to have been so charmed in reading the humor of Butler’s “Hudibras,” that he disguised himself as a private gentleman, and was introduced to the author, whom, to his astonishment, he found to be one of the *dullest* of companions. On the other hand, some of the humblest men

with whom one falls into company, possessed of but little variety, and less extent of information, are highly entertaining talkers. The particular topic of remark does not form so essential a part of an interesting conversation, as the words and manner of those who engage in it. Robert Burns, sitting down on one occasion to write a poem, said:

“Which way the subject theme may gang,  
Let time or chance determine;  
Perhaps it may turn out a sang,—  
Or probably a sermon.”

In the same manner, the subject of a conversation need not be made a matter of study, or special preparation. Men may talk of things momentous or trivial, and in either strain be alike attractive and agreeable.

But quitting the consideration of the thought, to refer to the mode of its expression, it must be remarked and insisted, that to “murder the king’s English” is hardly less a crime, than to design against one of the king’s subjects. If committed from ignorance, the fault is at least deplorable; but if from carelessness, it is inexcusable. The greatest of sciences is that of language; the greatest of human arts is that of using words. No “cunning hand” of the artificer can contrive a work of mechanism that is to be compared, for a moment, with those wonderful masterpieces of ingenuity, which may be wrought by him who can skilfully mould a beautiful thought into a form that shall preserve, yet radiate its beauty. A mosaic of words may be made more fair, than of inlaid precious stones. The scholar who comes forth from his study, a master of the English language, is a workman who has at his command hardly less than a hundred thousand finely-tempered instruments, with which he may fashion the most cunning device. This is a trade which all should learn, for it is one that every individual is called to practise. The greatest support of virtue in a community is intelligence; intelligence is the outgrowth of knowledge; and the almoner of all knowledge is language. The possession, therefore, of the resources, and a command over the appliances of language, is of the utmost importance to every individual. Words are current coins of the realm, and they who do not have them in their treasury, suffer a more pitiable poverty than others who have not a penny of baser specie in their pocket; and the multitude of those who have an unfailing supply, but which is of the wrong stamp, are

possessed only of counterfeit cash, that will not pass in circles of respectability. The present work therefore is, in some respects, not unlike the “Detector” issued for the merchants, to indicate the great amount of worthless money that is in general circulation with the good.

It is not to be supposed that all the mistakes of daily occurrence in the use of language, are to be numbered by “five hundred”—possibly not by five thousand; but it is evident that he who is instructed against five hundred of his habitual blunders, and enabled to steer clear of every one of them, has in no slight degree improved his conversation, and thereby increased his importance. As a prefix, or accompaniment, to this catalogue of corrected mistakes, the presentation of a few rules or principles of language, which, strictly observed, might guard against numerous general classes of errors, would not be thought misplaced, or undesirable. Some suggestions on points most prominent are accordingly given among these introductory remarks—not in formal statements of grammatical rules, but in examples in which the spirit of such rules is revealed.

Not the least glaring among the many misuses of words and forms of expression in conversation, occur by incorrectly employing the pronouns—*who*, *which*, *what*, and *that*. It may be remarked, that *who* should be applied exclusively to persons. *Which* usually refers to animals and inanimate objects, except in such an expression as, “Tell me *which* of the two men was chosen?” *What*, means *that which*: thus, “This is the book *what* I wanted,” should read, “This is the book *that* (or *which*) I wanted.”

Among interrogatives, *who?* inquires for the name; *which?* for the individual; *what?* for the character, or occupation. Thus, “*Who* built the bridge?” “Mr. Blake.” “*Which* of the Blakes?” “*Charles* Blake.” “*What* was he?” “A distinguished civil engineer.”

The title of a small book for young people, recently published, was—“The Way *that* Little Children enter Heaven:” the word *that* is here incorrectly used as a substitute for *in which*, or *by which*.

When *this* and *that*, and their plurals, are used in the sense of *latter* and *former*, *this* and *these* signify the *latter*, and *that* and *those* the *former*. Thus, in the following couplet from Burns:

“Farewell my friends, farewell my foes,  
My peace with *these*, my love with *those*.”

*these* refers to “foes,” and *those* to “friends.”

In the possessive case of nouns, some instances occur in which a wise choice may be made, but in respect to which usage is divided. Thus, we may say, “They called at *Walton’s the bookseller’s*,” or, with equal propriety, as far as custom is concerned, “at *Walton the bookseller’s*.” The first form, however, is preferable.

The use of the hyphen [-] is frequently disregarded in epistolary correspondence, occasioning not only a blemish but a blunder. Its importance may be seen by comparing the meaning of “*glass house*” with “*glass-house*,” the former may mean the Crystal Palace, while the latter is a manufactory of glass-ware.

Adjectives are often improperly used for adverbs: as, “*extreme* bad weather,” for “*extremely* bad weather.”

It is sometimes difficult to choose between such phrases as “the *first three*,” and “the *three first*.” To say *first three* when there is no *second three* is inelegant, because superfluous; and *three first* is absurd, because impossible. The most successful pupil in each of two classes at school would not improperly be called “the *two first boys*,” while propriety would require that the first and second boys of the same class should be called “the *first two boys*.” As a general rule, and easy to be recollected, let “*first*” be *first*.

The use of *some* for *about* is by many writers thought to be awkward: as, “*Some* fifty years ago,” instead of “*About* Fifty years.”

An ambiguity occasionally arises in employing the adjective *no*. Thus, “No money is better than gold,” may mean either that gold is the best kind of money, or that gold is not so good as *no money at all*!

After numerals, the words *couple*, *pair*, *dozen*, *score*, *hundred*, *thousand*, and a few others, need not take the plural form: thus, custom first, and finally grammar, have sanctioned such uses as, “three *pair* of shoes,” “nine

dozen bushels,” “four *couple* of students;” also, “*forty sail* of vessels,” “seventy *head* of cattle.”

The article (*a* or *an*) renders an important service in such expressions as, “A *few* followed their leader throughout the long struggle.” To say, “*Few* followed him,” would imply, unlike the former phrase, that he was almost deserted.

“A black and a white horse,” suggests the idea of two horses; while “a black and white horse,” refers to but one—as if written “a *black-and-white* horse.”

“The red and white dahlias were most admired,” properly means the dahlias in which both these colors were blended. “The red and *the* white dahlias,” implies two species.

The grammatical number of a verb should agree with that of its subject, and not of its predicate. Thus, the sentences, “Death *is* the wages of sin,” and “The wages of sin *are* death,” are properly written.

In changing from a past tense to the present, when the same nominative remains, the form of the verb should continue unaltered. Thus, instead of saying “He *was traveling* and *travels*,” say “He *was traveling* and *is traveling*.”

When a verb has both a singular and a plural nominative, separated by *or*, its number agrees with that of the *nearer*: as, “the cup or his *billiards were* his ruin;” or, “his billiards or the *cup was* his ruin.”

Custom—which, when *crystallized*, becomes grammar—allows expressions like “The linen *tears*,” and “The meadow *plows* well,” although they should not be frequently employed, and should be more seldom coined.

A fruitful source of mistakes in language, is in the linking together of two or more inappropriate tenses, or in the misuse of one. Many among the learned and refined commit blunders of these kinds. A few corrected examples of such are here given:

“His text was, that God *was* love;” the sentence should be written, “His text was, that God *is* love.”

“The Lord *hath given*, and the Lord *hath taken away*,” say, “The Lord *gave*, and the Lord *hath taken away*.”

“They *arrived* before we left the city:” say, “they *had arrived*.”

“All the brothers *have been* greatly indebted to their father:” say, “*are indebted*.”

“This painting *was preserved and exhibited* for the last century:” say, “*has been preserved and exhibited*.”

“It was the last act he intended *to have performed*.” say, “*to perform*.”

“He *drinks* wine at dinner,” means that such is his habit; “he *is drinking* wine at dinner,” refers to one particular time and occasion.

Adverbs are often inelegantly used instead of adjectives; as, “the *then* ministry,” for “the ministry of that time.”

Of the phrases “*never* so good,” or, “*ever* so good,” as to whether one is preferable to the other, authority is divided. Modern usage inclines to the latter, while ancient preferred the former, as in the Scriptural expression, “charm he *never* so wisely.”

*Yea* and *nay* are not equivalent to *yes* and *no*; the latter are directly affirmative and negative, while the former are variously employed.

Of prepositions, it has been frequently said, that no words in the language are so liable to be incorrectly used. For example, “The love *of* God,” may mean either “His love to us,” or, “our love to Him.”

Many more of these particles are inelegantly, if not ambiguously used. Instead of “the natives were a different race *to* what they are now,” say, “different *from*.”

“He was made much *on* in the country:” say, “made much *of*.”

“In compliance *of* your request:” say, “in compliance *with*.”

“He doubts *if* his friend will come,” is not so elegant and accurate as, “He doubts *whether* his friend will come.”

More instances might be given, setting forth other frequent errors of speaking and writing, at the risk, however, of destroying the due proportion which should exist between the size of a work and the *length of the Introduction*. But a good heed to what has been said in the few preceding paragraphs, will enable a person who carefully reads this work to mend his modes of expression, to no inconsiderable degree. It is well known that there is no “royal road to learning,” but if there were, it could hardly be expected that such a little book as this would afford a passport to the end of the course. About two hundred years ago, a small volume was put forth by one “John Peters, learned scholar and author,” which had the following long-winded title: “A New Way to make Latin Verses, whereby any one of ordinary capacity, that only *knows the A, B, C* and can *count nine*, though he understands not *one word of Latin*, or what a verse means, may be plainly taught to make thousands of Hexameter and Pentameter Verses, which shall be true Latin, true Verse, and Good Sense!” The present volume must not be expected to accomplish so great a result as this—not having so comprehensive an aim, nor possessing so great a secret of success. But it is hoped that it may incite some who are unfortunately deficient in education, to seek so much additional knowledge as shall enable them at least to converse in a dialect which is within the compass of the language of their country, and free them from the imputation of belonging to another tribe of men, speaking another tongue.

A Welshman, residing near Caermarthon, who was seldom seen at the only church in the parish of his residence, was one day accosted by the worthy clergyman with the question, “My friend—to what church do you belong?” He responded, “To the Church of England.” “Ah,” replied the pastor, “I was sure that it must be some church *out of Wales!*” There are not a few persons who speak the English language about as truly as the Caermarthon Welshman attended the English Church!

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## FIVE HUNDRED MISTAKES CORRECTED.

1. “The business would suit any one who *enjoys bad health*.” [From an advertisement in a daily newspaper of New-York.] Few persons who have bad health can be said to *enjoy it*. Use some other form of expression: as, one *in delicate health*, or, one *whose health is bad*.
2. “We have no *corporeal* punishment here,” said a schoolmaster. *Corporeal* is opposed to *spiritual*. Say, *corporal* punishment. *Corporeal* means having a body.
3. “She is a *notable* woman,” as was said of the wife of the Shepherd of Salisbury Plain,—meaning *careful*, and pronounced as though divided *not-able*. This word is no longer current, with this pronunciation or signification, except to a slight extent in England. It has become obsolete, and its use now is in bad taste.
4. “Insert the *advertisement* in the Weekly.” Emphasize *vert*, and not *ise*.
5. “He *rose up*, and left the room:” leave out *up*, as it is absurd to say *rise down*. The Irishman who was *hoisted down* the coal pit, did not observe this rule.
6. “*Set down* and rest yourself:” say *sit down*; *setting* is said of the sun in the west, but cannot be properly applied to a person taking a seat. “*Sit down*” is not improper, though “*rise up*” (as in No. 5) should never be used. *Sitting down* expresses the act of appropriating a chair, while *sitting up* means *sitting erect*. *Sitting up* also refers to watching during the night with the sick.
7. “You have *sown* it very neatly,” said a seamstress to her apprentice: say *sewed*, and pronounce so as to rhyme with *road*. The pronunciation of *sew*, meaning “to use the needle,” violates its spelling; it is the same as that of *sow*, meaning “to scatter seed.”
8. “This is a secret between *you and I*,” say, *you and me*. The construction requires the objective case in place of *I*, which is in the nominative. It is in

still better taste to say, “This is a secret *with* you and me.”

9. “Let *you and I* take a walk:” say, Let *you and me*, or, *Let us*. Who would think of saying, *Let I go*? The expression “Let *I and you*” is frequently heard, which contains the additional impropriety of putting the first person before the second.

10. “He is going to *learn his brother* Alfred how to knit nets:” say, *teach*. The act of *communicating* instruction is expressed by “teaching,” the act of *receiving* it by “learning.” The distinction between these words was made as early as the time of Shakespeare, and cannot be violated without incurring censure.

11. “John and Henry both read well, but John is the *best* reader:” say, the *better* reader, as *best* can be properly used only when *three or more persons*, or objects, are compared.

12. “Thompson was there *among the rest*.” This mode of expression, which is very common, literally declares an impossibility. The signification of “the rest” is, those *in addition* to Thompson, and of which Thompson formed *no part*; he could not therefore be *among* them. A more correct form would be, “Thompson was there *with* the rest.”

13. “The *two first* cows are the fattest,” said a farmer at an agricultural fair. He should have said, “the *first two*,” there can be only *one* that is *first*—the other must necessarily be *second*.

14. “It is an error; *you are mistaken*:” say, *you mistake*. *Mistaken* means *misapprehended*; “*you mistake*,” means “*you misapprehend*.”

15. “Have you *lit* the fire, Bridget?” say, *lighted*; *lit* is now obsolete.

16. “To be is an *auxiliary* verb:” pronounce *auxiliary* as though spelled *awg-zil-ya-re*, and not in five syllables.

17. *February*: this word is often incorrectly spelled by omitting the *r*.

18. The “*Miscellany*” was an interesting publication: pronounce *miscellany* with the accent on *mis*, and not on *cel*.

19. “*Celery* is a pleasant vegetable:” pronounce *celery* as it is written, and not *salary*.

20. “Are you at *leisure*?” pronounce *lei* in *leisure* the same as *lee*. The word should not rhyme with *measure*.

21. “John is my *oldest* brother:” say, *eldest*. *Elder* and *eldest* are applied to *persons*—*older* and *oldest* to *things*. Usage, however, does not make these distinctions imperative.

22. “The cloth was *wove* in a very short time:” say, *woven*.

23. “I prefer the *yolk* of an egg to the white:” the more common word is *yelk*, with the *l* sounded; but if *yolk* be used, it should be pronounced like *yoke*.

24. *Sparrowgrass*: it is only the grossest ignorance which confounds this word with *asparagus*. The same is the case with *ing-uns* for *onions*. A man in an obscure section of New Jersey, inquiring at a country store for *onions*, was told that there were none in the place. On his going out, the storekeeper turned to half a dozen idlers sitting round the stove, and said, “I wonder if that ’tarnal fool meant *ing-uns*!”

25. “You are very *mischievous*:” pronounce *mischievous* with the accent on *mis*, and not on *chie*, and do not say *mischievious* (*mis-cheev-yus*).

26. The following words were posted, as a sign, in a reading-room—“No Talking Allowed;” which was designed to prohibit all conversation. A wag altered the inscription so as to read, “No Talking Aloud,” which (he declared) did not prevent *whispering*, and chatting in *low tones*. What shall be said of the following—“No Smoking Aloud?”

27. “No *extras* or *vacations*:” [from the prospectus of a schoolmistress:] say, *NOR vacations*.

28. “He was never known to be *covetous*:” pronounce *covetous* as if written *covet us*, and not *covetyus*.

29. *The Three R.’s*.—An ignorant and vain pedagogue, on being asked what he could teach, replied, “The three R.’s—’*ritin*’, ’*rethmetic*’, and *readin*’.”

Any persons among the readers of this little book, who may chance to be schoolmasters, are warned against giving such a course of instruction.

30. "Dearly *beloved* brethren:" when *beloved* is placed *before* the noun, as in this instance, pronounce it in three syllables; when placed *after*, in two syllables, as, "She was much *be-loved* by us all." When used as a noun by itself, it is pronounced in three syllables; as, "*Be-lov-ed*, let us love one another."

31. "Not *as I know*:" say, *that I know*.

32. "He came on purpose *for to do* it:" omit *for*.

33. "He would never believe *but what* I did it:" say, *but that* I did it.

34. "He is quite *as good as me*:" say, *as good as I*. Also, instead of *as good as him*, say, *as good as he*. In both these instances *am* or *is* must be mentally supplied at the end of the phrase, to suggest the meaning; and the pronouns should, therefore, be in the nominative case.

35. "*Many an one* has done the same:" say, *many a one*. *A*, and *not an*, is also used before the *long sound of u*, that is, when *u* forms a *distinct syllable of itself*: as, *a unit, a union, a university*: it is also used before *eu*: as, *a euphony*, and likewise before the word *ewe*: as, *a ewe*: we should also say, *a youth*, not *an youth*.

36. "How do you like *these kind* of pears?" say, *these kinds*; a noun in the singular number will not allow its adjective to be in the plural.

37. "You should have *went* home:" say, *gone*.

38. "John went with *James and I*:" say, *James and me*.

39. "I *see him* last Monday:" say, *saw him*.

40. "He was *averse from* such a proceeding:" say, *averse to*.

41. "Have you *shook* the table-cloth?" say, *shaken*.

42. "I have *rang* several times:" say, *rung*.

43. "I *know'd* him at once:" say, *knew*.

44. "You have *drank* too much of it:" say, *drunk*.
45. "He has *chose* a very poor pattern:" say, *chosen*.
46. "They have *broke* a window:" say, *broken*.
47. "I have just *began* my letter:" say, *begun*.
48. "Give me *them books*:" say, *those books*.
49. "Whose are *these here books*?" say, *these books*. *Here* is superfluous and inelegant.
50. "Who do you mean?" say, *whom*.
51. "The men *which* we saw:" say, *whom*.
52. "The flowers *what* you have:" say, *which*, or *that*.
53. "The boy *as* is reading:" *who* is reading.
54. "It was *them* who did it:" say, *they*.
55. "*It is me* who am in fault:" say, *It is I*.
56. "Was it *her* who called me?" say, *she*.
57. "If I were *her*, I would accept his offer:" say, If I were *she*.
58. "He *has got* my slate:" omit *got*; *has* is sufficient for the sense. The addition of *got*, though not ungrammatical, but gradually becoming obsolete, does not in any degree strengthen the meaning.
59. "The pond is *froze*:" say, *frozen*.
60. "I know *I am him* whom he meant:" say, *I am he*.
61. "You cannot *catch* him:" pronounce *catch* so as to rhyme with *match*, and not *ketch*—as the fishermen are in the habit of saying.
62. "Who *done* it?" say, *Who did it?*
63. "The club gives an *impetus* to the ball:" pronounce *impetus* with the stress on *im*, and not on *pe*.

64. “Spain and Portugal form a *peninsula*.” pronounce *pen-in-su-la*, with the accent on *in*, and not on *su*.

65. *Sar-da-na-pa-lus*: pronounce it with the accent on *pa*, and not on *ap*. The latter pronunciation cannot be changed for the former, without incurring a gross error.

66. “He must by this time be almost as far as the *antipodes*.” pronounce *antipodes* with the accent on *tip*, and let *des* rhyme with *ease*; it is a word of *four* syllables, and *not of three*.

67. *Vouchsafe*: a word seldom used, but when used, the first syllable should rhyme with *pouch*; *never say vousafe*.

68. “The land in those parts is very *fertile*.” pronounce *fertile* so as to rhyme with *myrtle*. *Ile* in such words must be sounded as *ill*, with the exception of *exile*, *senile*, *gentile*, *reconcile*, and *camomile*, in which *ile* rhymes with *mile*.

69. *Benefited*: often spelt *benefitted*, but *incorrectly*.

70. “Gather a few ears of corn for dinner.” pronounce *gather* so as to rhyme with *lather*, and *not gether*.

71. *Purpose* and *propose*: these two words, which are often confounded, are entirely distinct in meaning. To *purpose* means *to intend*; to *propose* means *to offer a proposition*.

72. *Directing* and *addressing* letters: *Directing* designates the persons to whom, and the place to which the letter, as a parcel, is to be sent; *addressing* refers to the individual to whom, as a communication, it is written. A letter *addressed* to the President, may be *directed* to his secretary.

73. “Who do you think I saw yesterday?” say, *Whom*.

74. A popular proverb is expressed in the following language: “Of *two* evils choose the *least*,” say, *the less*. Of no less than *three* evils can a person choose the *least*.

75. *Exaggerate*: pronounce *exad-gerate*, and *do not sound agger* as in *dagger*.

76. *Ladies School*: the usual form, but *not correct*; write, *Ladies' School*. The apostrophe (') is thus used after nouns in the plural, and indicates *possession*. In the singular, it is placed *before the s*, as, *The lady's school*.

77. The following equivocal notice is said to swing out on a sign-board somewhere in the Western country: "SMITH & HUGGS—SELECT SCHOOL.—*Smith teaches the boys, and Huggs the girls.*" *Huggs needs correction!*

78. "He keeps a *chaise*:" pronounce it *shaze*, and not *shay*; it has a regular plural, *chaises*.

79. "The *drought* lasted a long time:" pronounce *drought* so as to rhyme with *sprout*, and not *drowth*.

80. "The two friends *conversed together* for an hour:" omit *together*, as the full meaning of this word is implied in *con*, which means *with*, or *together*, or *in company*.

81. "The affair was *compromised*:" pronounce *compromised* in three syllables, and place the accent on *com*, sounding *mised* like *prized*.

82. "A *steam-engine*:" pronounce *engine* with *en* as in *pen*, and *not like in*; also, pronounce *gine* like *gin*.

83. "Several of the trappers were massacred by the Indians:" pronounce *massacred* with the accent on *mas*, and *red* like *erd*, as if *massaker'd*; never say *massacreed*, which is abominable.

84. "The King of Israel and the King of Judah sat *either of them* on his throne:" say, *each of them*. *Either* signifies the *one* or the *other*, but *not both*. *Each* relates to *two or more objects*, and signifies *both of the two*, or *every one of any number taken singly*. We can say, "*either of the three*," for "*one of the three*."

85. "A *respite* was granted the convict:" pronounce *respite* with the accent on *res*, and sound *pite* as *pit*.

86. "He soon *returned back*:" leave out *back*, which is implied by *re* in *returned*.

87. “The ship looked like a speck on the edge of the *horizon*.” pronounce *horizon* with the accent on *ri*, and not on *hor*, which is often the case.

88. “They were early at the *sepulchre*.” pronounce *sepulchre* with the accent on *sep*, and not on the second syllable.

89. “I have often *swam* across the Hudson.” say, *swum*.

90. “I found my friend better than I expected *to have found him*.” say, *to find him*.

91. “I intended *to have written* a letter yesterday.” say, *to write*; as however long it now is since I thought of writing, “*to write*” was then present to me, and must still be considered as present, when I recall that time and the thoughts of it.

92. *Superfluous R's*: Many persons pronounce words which have no letter *r* in them, exactly as though they had; as *drawring* for *drawing*; “I *sawr* Thomas,” for “I *saw*,” &c. Some who do not insert a full-toned *r*, do worse by appending an *ah* to almost every word they utter. They would do well to recall the reproof which the excellent Rev. John Gruber administered to a brother in the ministry, who was guilty of this habit. That eccentric clergyman addressed a note to his friend, as follows: “Dear-ah Sir-ah—When-ah you-ah speak-ah in-ah public-ah, take-ah my-ah ad-ah-vice-ah and-ah never-ah say-ah *ah-ah*!—JOHN-AH GRUBER-AH.”

93. *Shall* and *will* are often confounded, or misused. The following suggestion will be of service to the reader: mere *futurity* is expressed by *shall* in the *first* person, and by *will* in the *second* and *third*; the *determination* of the speaker by *will*, in the *first*, and *shall*, in the *second* and *third*. For example: “*I shall go by the way of Halifax*,” simply expresses an event about to take place—as also *you will*, and *they will*: *I will* expresses determination—as also *you shall* and *they shall*. Brightland has the following illustrative stanza:

“In the first person simply *shall* foretells;  
In *will* a threat, or else a promise, dwells.  
*Shall*, in the second and the third, does threat;—  
*Will*, simply, then, foretells the future feat.”

94. “*Without* the grammatical form of a word can be recognized at a glance, little progress can be made in reading the language:” [from a work on the study of the Latin language:] say, *Unless* the grammatical, &c. The use of *without* for *unless* is a very common mistake.

95. “He claimed admission to the *chiefest* offices:” say, *chief*. *Chief*, *right*, *supreme*, *correct*, *true*, *universal*, *perfect*, *consummate*, *extreme*, &c., imply the superlative degree without adding *est*, or prefixing *most*. In language sublime or impassioned, however, the word *perfect* requires the superlative form, to give it its fullest effect.

96. “I *had rather* do it now:” say, I *would rather* do. The incorrectness of the first form of expression is very clearly seen by cutting out *rather*, leaving “I *had* do,” which is ungrammatical and meaningless.

97. An obituary notice contained the following ludicrous statement: “He left a large circle of mourners, *embracing his amiable wife and children!*” *Comprising* should have been used, instead of *embracing*.

98. “His *court-of-arms* is very splendid:” say, *coat-of-arms*.

99. “They ride about in small carriages, which are called *flies*:” write the last word *flys*; *flies* is the plural of *fly*, the insect.

100. “Victoria is Queen of the *United Kingdom*:” say, *United Kingdoms*. Who ever speaks of the *United State of America*?

101. “I have not traveled *this twenty years*:” say, *these twenty years*.

102. “Soldier arms!” Say, “*Shoulder arms!*” The latter is frequently corrupted into “*Sojer arms!*”

103. “He is *very much the gentleman*:” say, He is *a very gentlemanly man*, or, *He is very gentlemanly*.

104. “The *yellow* part of an egg is very nourishing:” never pronounce *yellow* so as to rhyme with *tallow*, as we so often hear.

105. “We are going to the *Zoological* Gardens:” pronounce *Zoological* in five syllables, and place the accent on *log* in *logical*; sound *log* like *lodge*, and the first two o’s in distinct syllables; never make *Zool* one syllable.

106. “He *strived* to obtain an appointment:” say, *strove*.

107. “He always preaches *extempore*,” pronounce *extempore* in four syllables, with the accent on *tem*, and never in three, making *pore* to rhyme with *sore*—but with *story*.

108. “Allow me to *suggest*,” pronounce *sug* as to rhyme with *mug*, and *gest* like *jest*; never say *sudjest*.

109. “That building is an *episcopal* chapel,” pronounce *episcopal* with the accent on the second syllable, and *not* on *co*.

110. “The Emperor of Russia is a *formidable* sovereign,” pronounce *formidable* with the accent on *for*, and *not* on *mid*.

111. Before the words *heir*, *herb*, *honest*, *honor*, and *hour*, and their compounds, instead of the article *a*, we make use of *an*, as the *h* is not sounded; likewise before words beginning with *h*, that are not accented on the first syllable: such as *heroic*, *historical*, *hypothesis*, &c., as, “*an heroic action*,” “*an historical work*,” “*an hypothesis that can scarcely be allowed*.” The letter *h* is seldom mute at the beginning of a word; but from the negligence of tutors, and the inattention of pupils, many persons have become almost incapable of acquiring its just and full pronunciation. It is, therefore, incumbent on teachers to be particularly careful to inculcate a clear and distinct utterance of this sound.

112. “He was *such an extravagant young man*, that he soon spent his whole patrimony.” This construction, which is much used, is not so elegant as, “He was *so extravagant a young man*,” &c.

113. “The girl speaks *distinct*,” say, *distinctly*. Never use *Adjectives as Adverbs*.

114. “The accident of which he was *reading*, occurred not far from *Reading*,” pronounced the first italicized word to rhyme with *feeding*, and the other, with *wedding*.

115. The combination of letters *ough* is pronounced in eight different ways, as follows: 1. *Though*, in which it is pronounced *o*; 2. *Through*, pronounced *oo*; 3. *Plough*, *ow*; 4. *Sought*, *awe*; 5. *Cough*, *off*; 6. *Rough*, *uff*; 7. *Borough*,

ugh; 8. *Lough*, *ok*. The following sentence, which is of doubtful authorship, affords an example of each of these eight modes of pronunciation: "I put (1) *dough* (6) *enough* in the (5) *trough* near the (3) *slough* by the (8) *lough*, to last the ducks that I (4) *bought* at the (7) *borough* (2) *through* the day."

116. "I saw his *august* majesty, the Emperor of Hayti, last *August*:" pronounce the former word with the accent on *gust*; the latter, on *Au*.

117. "She is *quite the lady*:" say, She is *very lady-like in her demeanor*.

118. "He is *seldom or ever* out of town:" say, *seldom or never*, or, *seldom if ever*.

119. "We *laid down* to sleep:" say, we *lay down*, &c. We can say, however, "we *laid him* down to sleep."

120. It is somewhat singular, that while *tie* and *untie* convey meanings directly opposite, *loose* and *unloose* signify precisely the same thing. *Loose* is the original word, and *unloose* is a corruption; both words, however, are now sanctioned by good usage, and may be indiscriminately employed, without offence against propriety.

121. "It is dangerous to walk *of a* slippery morning:" say, *on a* slippery morning. But the expression, "*walking on a slippery morning*," and all others like it, of which a strictly literal interpretation will not give the designed signification, are to be avoided. They often excite a smile when seriousness is intended.

122. "He who makes himself famous by his eloquence, makes illustrious his origin, let it be *never so mean*:" say, *ever so mean*. The practice of using *never* in such phrases was anciently in vogue, but is now becoming obsolete. (See Introduction.)

123. "His reputation is acknowledged *through* Europe:" say, *throughout* Europe.

124. "The bank of the river is frequently *overflown*:" say, *overflowed*. *Flown* is the perfect participle of *fly*, *flying*; *flowed*, of *flow*, *flowing*.

125. "I doubt *if this* will ever reach you:" say, *whether this*, &c.

126. "It is not improbable *but I may* be able to procure you a copy:" say, *that I may, &c.*

127. "He was *exceeding kind* to me:" say, *exceedingly kind.*

128. "I doubt not *but I shall* be able:" say, *that I shall.*

129. "I lost *near* twenty pounds:" say, *nearly, or almost.*

130. "There were not *over* twenty persons present:" say, *more than.* Such a use of this word is not frequent among writers of reputation. It may, however, be less improperly employed, where the sense invests it with more of a semblance to its literal signification: as, "This pair of chickens will weigh *over* seven pounds." Even in this case, it is better to say *more than.*

131. "*Bills are requested to be paid quarterly:*" *the bills are not requested, but the persons who owe them.* Say instead, *It is requested that bills be paid quarterly.*

132. "There can be no doubt *but that* he will succeed:" omit *but.*

133. "It was *no use asking* him any more questions:" say, *of no use to ask him, or there was no use in asking, &c.*

134. "The Americans said they *had no right* to pay taxes." [From a Fourth of July Oration.] They certainly *had a right* to pay them, if they wished. What the speaker meant was, *they were under no obligation to pay, or, they were not bound to pay.*

135. "He intends to *stop* at home for a few days:" it is more elegant to say *stay.* If the time, however, should be very brief, *stop* would better express the idea; as, "We *stopped* at Elmira about twenty minutes."

136. "At this time, I *grew* my own corn:" say, I *raised.* Farmers have made this innovation against good taste; but for what reason, it is not apparent; there seems to be no sufficient occasion for so awkward a substitute for *raised.*

137. "Having incautiously *laid down* on the damp grass, he caught a severe cold:" say, *lain down.*

138. “We suffered no other inconvenience *but* that arising from the rain:” say, *than* that, &c. *But*, to be properly used in this sentence, would require the omission of *other*.

139. “Brutus and Aruns killed *one another*,” say, *each other*, which is more proper. But many similar instances which occur in the New Testament, as, “*Beloved, love one another*,” and others no less beautiful and cherished, have rendered this form of expression common, and almost unexceptionable.

140. In a recently issued work on Arithmetic, the following is given: “If for 72 cents I can buy 9 lbs. of raisins, *how much* can I purchase for \$14 49?” say, “*what quantity* can I,” &c. Who would think of saying, “*how much raisins?*”

141. WORDS TO BE CAREFULLY DISTINGUISHED.—Be very careful to distinguish between *indite* and *indict* (the former meaning *to write*, and the latter *to accuse*); *key* and *quay*; *principle* and *principal*; *marshal* and *martial*; *counsel* and *council*; *counsellor* and *councillor*; *fort* and *forte*; *draft* and *draught*; *place* and *plaice* (the latter being the name of a fish); *stake* and *steak*; *satire* and *satyr*; *stationery* and *stationary*; *ton* and *tun*; *levy* and *levee*; *foment* and *ferment*; *fomentation* and *fermentation*; *petition* and *partition*; *Francis* and *Frances*; *dose* and *doze*; *diverse* and *divers*; *device* and *devise*; *wary* and *weary*; *salary* and *celery*; *radish* and *reddish*; *treble* and *triple*; *broach* and *brooch*; *ingenious* and *ingenuous*; *prophecy* and *prophecy* (some clergymen sounding the final syllable of the latter word long, like the former); *fondling* and *foundling*; *lightning* and *lightening*; *genus* and *genius*; *desert* and *dessert*; *currier* and *courier*; *pillow* and *pillar*; *executer* and *executor* (the former being the regular noun from the verb “to execute,” and the latter a strictly legal term); *ridicule* and *reticule*; *lineament* and *liniment*; *track* and *tract*, *lickerish* and *licorice* (*lickerish* signifying *dainty*, and *licorice* being a plant, or preparation from it); *statute* and *statue*; *ordinance* and *ordnance*; *lease* and *leash*; *recourse* and *resource*; *straight* and *strait* (*straight* meaning *direct*, and *strait*, *narrow*); *immerge* and *emerge*; *style* and *stile*; *compliment* and *complement*; *bass* and *base*; *contagious* and *contiguous*; *eminent* and *imminent*; *eruption* and *irruption*; *precedent* and *president*; *relic* and *relict*.

142. "The number of *emigrants* arriving in this country is increasing and alarming:" say, *immigrants*. *Emigrants* are those *going out* from a country; *immigrants*, those *coming into* it.

143. "I prefer *radishes* to *cucumbers*:" pronounce *radishes* exactly as spelt, and not *redishes*; also, the first syllable of *cucumber* like *fu* in *fuel*, and not as if the word were spelled *cowcumber*.

144. "The *two last* letters were dated from Calcutta:" say, the *last two*, &c.

145. "The soil in those islands is so very thin, that little is produced in them *beside* cocoa-nut trees:" "*beside* cocoa-nut trees" means strictly *alongside*, or *by the side*, of them. *Besides*, or *except*, should be used. *Besides* also signifies *in addition to*: as, "I sat *beside* the President, and conversed with him *besides*."

146. "He could neither *read nor write*:" say, more properly, *write nor read*. All persons who can *write* can *read*, but not all who *read* can *write*. This sentence, as corrected, is much stronger than in the other form.

147. "He was *bred and born* among the hills of the Hudson:" say, *born and bred*, which is the natural order.

148. "THIS HOUSE TO LET:" more properly, *to be let*.

149. *Here, there, where*, with verbs of motion, are generally better than *hither, thither, whither*; as, "*Come here; Go there*." *Hither, thither, and whither*, which were used formerly, are now considered stiff and inelegant.

150. "As *far as I* am able to judge, the book is well written:" say, *So far as*, &c.

151. "It is doubtful whether he will act *fairly or no*:" say, *fairly or not*.

152. "The *camelopard* is the tallest of known animals:" pronounce *camelopard* with the accent on *mel*; never say *camel leopard*. Few words, by being mispronounced, occasion greater blunders than this term.

153. "He ran *again* me;" or, "I stood *again* the hydrant:" say, *against*. This word is frequently and inelegantly abbreviated, in pronunciation, into *agin*.

154. “No one should incur censure for being careful of *their* good character:” say, of *his* (or *her*).

155. “The yacht capsized in rounding the stake-boat, and the helmsman was *drownded*.” say, *drowned*.

156. “*Jalap* will be of service to you:” pronounce the word as it is spelled, never saying *jollop*.

157. The word *curiosity*, though a very common term, and one that should be correctly pronounced by everybody, is frequently called *curosimy*.

158. “He has just set out to *take a tour*.” pronounce *tour* so as to rhyme with *poor*. Be careful to avoid saying, *take a tower*; such a pronunciation might suggest the Mamelon, instead of a trip of travel.

159. “The storm *is* ceased, and the sky is clear:” say, *has* ceased.

160. “Do you know *who* this dog-headed cane belongs to?” say, *whom*. In expressing in *writing* the idea conveyed in this question, a better form of sentence would be, “Do you know *to whom* this belongs?” In familiar conversation, however, the latter mode might be thought too formal and precise.

161. “*Who* did you wish to see?” say, *whom*.

162. “*Whom* say ye that I am?” This is the English translation, given in Luke ix. 20, of the question of Christ to Peter. The word *whom* should be *who*. Other instances of grammatical inaccuracies occur in the Bible; for example, in the Sermon on the Mount, the Saviour says: “Lay not up for yourselves treasures on earth, where *moth and rust doth corrupt*,” &c. “*Moth and rust*” make a plural nominative to “*doth corrupt*,” a singular verb. The following, however, is correct: “But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where *neither moth nor rust doth corrupt*.”

163. The word *chimney* is sometimes called incorrectly *chimley* and *chimbley*.

164. “I was walking *towards* home:” pronounce *towards* so as to rhyme with *boards*; never say, *to-wards*.

165. “A *courier* is expected from Washington:” pronounce *cou* in *courier* so as to rhyme with *too*, never like *currier*; the two words have entirely distinct significations.

166. “Let each of us mind *their* own business:” say, *his* own business.

167. “Who made that noise? Not *me*:” say, Not *I*.

168. “Is this or that the *best* road?” say, the *better* road.

169. “*Rinse* your mouth:” pronounce *rinse* as it is written, and never *rense*. “*Rench* your mouth,” said a fashionable dentist one day to a patient. “You have already *wrenched it for me*,” was the reply.

170. “He was tired of the dust of the town, and *flew* to the pure air of the country:” say, *fled*. *Flew* is part of the verb *to fly*; *fled*, of *to flee*.

171. “The first edition was not *as* well printed as the present:” say, so well, &c.

172. “The Unabridged Dictionary was his greatest work, it being the labor of a life-time:” pronounce *Dictionary* as if written *Dik-shun-a-ry*; not, as is too commonly the practice, *Dixonary*.

173. “I should feel sorry to be *beholding* to him:” say, *beholden*.

174. “He is a *despicable* fellow, and such an epitaph is strictly *applicable* to him:” *never* place the accent in *despicable* and *applicable* on the *second* syllable, but *always* on the *first*.

175. “Some disaster has certainly *befell* him:” say, *befallen*.

176. Carefully distinguish between *sergeant* and *serjeant*: both are pronounced *sarjant*, but the *former* is used in a military sense, and the *latter* applied to a lawyer. These distinctions are, however, observed chiefly in England.

177. “She is a pretty *creature*:” never pronounce *creature* like *creetur*.

178. The following expression would be of special significance on coming from a surgeon or anatomist: “Desiring to know your friend better, *I took him apart* to converse with him.” It has been said that two persons who *take*

*each other apart*, frequently do so for the express purpose of *putting their heads together*.

179. “I am very wet, and must go and *change myself*,” say, *change my clothes*.

180. “He is taller *than me*,” say, *than I*.

181. “He is much better *than me*,” say, *than I*.

182. “You are stronger *than him*,” say, *than he*.

183. “That is the *moot* point,” say, *disputed* point. The other word is inelegant, and nearly obsolete.

184. “They are at *loggerheads*”: this is an extremely unpoetical figure to express the mutual relations of two individuals who have an “honest difference;” say, at *variance*, or use some other form of expression. It might just as well be said, “They are at *tadpoles*!”

185. “He paid a *florin* to the *florist*,” divide the syllables so as to pronounce like *flor-in* and *flo-rist*.

186. “His character is *undeniable*,” a very common expression: say, *unexceptionable*.

187. “Bring me the *lantern*,” never spell *lantern*—*lanthorn*.

188. “The room is twelve *foot* long, and nine *foot* broad,” say, twelve *feet*, nine *feet*.

189. “He is a *Highlander*,” never say, *Heelander*.

190. “He is *singular*, though *regular* in his habits, and also very *particular*,” beware of leaving out the *u* in *singular*, *regular*, and *particular*, which is a very common practice.

191. “They are detained *at France*,” say, *in France*.

192. “He lives *at New-York*,” say, *in New-York*.

193. "He is very *dry*" (meaning *thirsty*), is a very common and very improper word to use: say, *thirsty*.

194. "No *less* than fifty persons were there:" say, *fewer*, &c. *Less* refers to *quantity*; *fewer* to *number*.

195. "*Such another* victory, and we shall be ruined:" say, *Another such* victory, &c.

196. "It is *some distance*, from our house:" say, *at some distance*, &c.

197. "I shall call *upon* him:" say, *on* him.

198. "Remove those *trestles*:" pronounce *trestles* exactly as written, only leaving out the *t*; never say *trussles*.

199. "He is much addicted to *raillery*:" in pronouncing *raillery*, leave out the *i*; never say, *rail-le-ry*.

200. "He is a Doctor of *Medicine*:" pronounce *medicine* in *three* syllables, NEVER in *two*.

201. "They told me to enter *in*:" leave out *in*, as it is implied in *enter*.

202. "His *strength* is failing:" never say, *strenth*.

203. "Give me both *of* those books:" leave out *of*.

204. "*Whenever* I try to write well, I *always* find I can do it:" leave out *always*, which is unnecessary and improper.

205. "He plunged *down* into the stream:" leave out *down*.

206. "I never saw his *nephew*:" say, *nef-ew*; never *nev-u*, or *nevvey*.

207. "She is the *matron*:" say, *may-tron*, and not *mat-ron*.

208. "Give me *leave* to tell you:" never say *lief* for *leave*.

209. "The *height* is considerable:" pronounce *height* so as to rhyme with *tight*; never *hate* nor *heighth*. An instance occurs in "Paradise Lost" in which this word is spelled and pronounced *highth*.

210. "Who has my *scissors*?" never call *scissors*, *sithers*.

211. "He has obtained a good *situation*:" pronounce *situation* as if written *sit-you-a-tion*, and do not say, *sitch-u-a-tion*.

212. "I had as *lief* do it as not:" *lief* means *willingly*, *gladly*, and is not to be confounded with *leave*, as in example No. 208.

213. "First *of all* I shall give you a lesson in French, and last *of all* in music:" omit *of all* in both instances, as unnecessary.

214. "I shall have finished by the *latter* end of the week:" leave out *latter*, which is superfluous.

215. "They sought him *throughout* the *whole* country:" leave out *whole*, which is implied in *throughout*.

216. "Iron sinks *down* in water:" leave out *down*.

217. "A warrant was *issued out* for his apprehension:" leave out the word *out*, which is implied in *issued*.

218. "If you inquire *for why* I did so, I can give a very good reason:" leave out *for*.

219. "I own that I did not come soon enough; but *because why*? I was detained:" leave out *because*.

220. "I *cannot by no means* allow it:" say, *I can by no means*, &c.; or, *I cannot by any means*, &c.

221. "He *covered it over*:" leave out *over*.

222. "I bought *a new pair of shoes*:" say, *a pair of new shoes*.

223. "He *combined together* these facts:" leave out *together*.

224. "My brother called on me, and we *both* took a walk:" leave out *both*, which is unnecessary.

225. "Evil spirits are not occupied about the *dead corpses* of bad men:" leave out *dead*, which is altogether unnecessary, as it is *implied* in the word

corpses, “corpse” and “dead body” being strictly synonymous.

226. “He has gone to the *Lyceum*.” pronounce *Lyceum* with the accent on the second syllable, and not on the first.

227. “This is a picture of *Westminster Abbey*.” never say *Westminister*, as if there were two words, *West-minister*.

228. “We are going to take a *holiday*.” this word was originally spelled and pronounced *holyday*, being compounded of the two words *holy* (meaning “set apart”) and *day*. Custom, however, has changed the orthography from *y* to *i*, and made the first syllable rhyme with *Poll*.

229. “It was referred to the *Committee* on Ways and Means.” emphasize the second, not the first syllable.

230. “He is now settled in *Worcester*.” pronounce as if written *Wooster*. *Gloucester* and *Leicester* are pronounced *Gloster* and *Lester*. The termination *cester* or *chester*, occurring in the names of many English towns, is derived and corrupted from the Latin *Castra*, camps; and every town so named is supposed to have been the site of a camp of soldiers, during the possession of Britain by the Romans.

231. “*Relatives* and *Relations*.” both these words designate kinsfolk, and are in most instances used indiscriminately. *Relatives*, however, is by some deemed the more proper and elegant.

232. “What a long *lirry* he has to say!” This word should be pronounced and spelt *lurry*; its more general meaning is a “heap,” a “throng,” a “crowd,” but is often applied to a long dull speech.

233. “*Diamonds* are charcoals.” pronounce *diamonds* in three syllables.

234. “Honor to the *patriot* and the sage.” divide the syllables like *pa-tri-ot*, not *pat-ri-ot*. Irish rowdyism has been called “*Pat-riot-ism*.”

235. “Do you *believe* that he will *receive* my letter?” observe that in the former word the diphthong is *ie*, and in the latter *ei*. A convenient rule for the spelling of such words is the following: *c* takes *ei* after it; all other consonants are followed by *ie*:—as, deceive, reprieve.

236. “He is now confirmed in *idiotcy*,” say, *idiocy*; the *t* in *idiot* is dropped in forming the word.

237. “He raised the *national* standard,” pronounce the first two syllables like the word *nation*, never as if written *nash-ion-al*.

238. *Principal* and *Principle*: be careful to observe the distinction between these words. *Principal* signifies *chief*; *principle*, *motive*.

239. “He favors the *Anti-Slavery* reform,” pronounce *Anti* with a distinct sounding of the *i*; else the word becomes *ante*, which means not “against,” but “before,”—as “ante-deluvian,” signifying “before the Deluge.”

240. *Cincinnati* is often misspelled *Cincinnatti*. The name is derived from *Cincinnatus*, a celebrated Roman.

241. “Her dress was made of *moiré antique*,” *moiré antique* is an article of *watered silk*, very well known to the “shopping” sisterhood, but very frequently called “*Murray Antique*.”

242. “It was mentioned in a *Californian newspaper*,” say, *California* newspaper. No one says *Philadelphian*, or *Chicagonian* journal.

243. “The lecture was *characterized* as a brilliant performance,” accent the first, and not the second syllable.

244. “This is one of the traditions of St. *Helena*,” accent *le*, and not *Hel*.

245. “The boy was found by a *washwoman*,” say, *washerwoman*.

246. “St. John’s is about two days nearer England than Halifax.” [From an account, in a New-York newspaper, of the Submarine Telegraph Expedition, September, 1855.] Does it mean that St. John’s is nearer to England than Halifax is, or nearer to England than to Halifax?

247. “He wears a blue-spotted *neck-handkerchief*,” say, *neckerchief*, or, still better, *neck-cloth*, or *cravat*. The original word is *kerchief*, and not *handkerchief*, which is a *kerchief* for the *hand*.

248. “The city was *illumined* in honor of the victory,” better say, *illuminated*. Distinguish between the pronunciation of *illumined* and *ill-*

omened.

249. “She has brought the *cloze pins* in a bag:” say, *clothes’ pins*.

250. “He met with *luck*:” say either “*bad luck*,” or “*good luck*,” *luck* primarily refers to simple “chance,” although its derivatives, *lucky* and *luckily*, imply only *good fortune*.

251. “The *in-va-lid* signed a deed, that was *in-val-id*:” pronounce the former “*invalid*” with the accent on the *first* syllable; the *latter*, with the accent on the *second*.

252. “The *duke* discharged his *duty*.” Be careful to give the slender, clear sound of *u*. Avoid saying *dook* and *dooty*, or *doo* for *dew* or *due*. Say *flute*, not *flood*; *suit*, not *soot*; *mute*, not *moot*. As well might you say *bute* for *boot*, or *shute* for *shoot*.

253. “*Genealogy*, *geography*, and *geometry* are words of Greek derivation:” beware of saying *geneology*, *jography*, and *jometry*, a very common practice.

254. “He made out the *inventory*:” place the accent in *inventory* on the syllable *in*, and NEVER on *ven*.

255. “He deserves *chastisement*:” say, *chas-tiz-ment*, with the accent on *chas*, and NEVER on *tise*.

256. “He threw the *rind* away:” never call *rind*, *rine*.

257. “His *knowledge* is very great:” always pronounce *knowledge* so as to rhyme with *college*, and NEVER say *know-ledge*.

258. “They contributed to his *maintenance*:” pronounce *maintenance* with the accent on *main*, and never say *maintainance*.

259. “She wears a silk *gown*:” never say *gownd*.

260. “Maine is a *maritime* State:” pronounce the last syllable of *maritime* so as to rhyme with *rim*.

261. “They *desisted* from their *design*:” pronounce the *former s* in *desisted* with a soft sound, and *always* pronounce *design* as if written *de-zine*.

262. “They committed a *heinous* crime:” pronounce *heinous* as if spelled *hay-nus*; NEVER call the word *hee-nus* or *hain-yus*.

263. “He *hovered* about the enemy:” pronounce *hovered* so as to rhyme with *covered*.

264. “He is a powerful *ally*:” never place the accent on *al* in *ally*, as many do.

265. “We have never been called, almost, to the consideration of the Apocalypse, without finding fresh reasons for our opinion.” [Such are the words of a very eminent reviewer.] He should have said, “We have *scarcely* ever been called,” or, “we have *almost never*.”

266. “He is very *bigoted*:” never spell the last word with *double t*, a very common mistake.

267. “The *Weekly Tribune* has a large circulation:” pronounce *Tribune* as if divided *Trib-une*, and not *Try-bune*.

268. “He said *as how* you was to do it:” say, he said *that you were to do it*.

269. Never say, “*I acquiesce with you*,” but, “*I acquiesce in your proposal, in your opinion*,” &c.

270. “He is a distinguished *antiquarian*:” say, *antiquary*. *Antiquarian* is an adjective; *antiquary*, a noun.

271. An injudicious disposition of a clause in a sentence frequently creates great merriment in the reading. In Goldsmith’s “History of England,” a book remarkable for its carelessness of style, we find the following extraordinary sentence, in one of the chapters of the reign of Queen Elizabeth: “This” [a communication to Mary Queen of Scots] “they effected by conveying their letters to her by means of a brewer that *supplied the family with ale through a chink in the wall of her apartment*.” A queer brewer that—to supply ale through a chink in the wall! How easy the alteration to make the passage clear! “This they effected by conveying their letters to her *through a chink in the wall of her apartment, by means of a brewer that supplied the family with ale*.”

272. “Lavater wrote on *Physiognomy*:" in the last word sound the *g* distinctly, as *g* is always pronounced before *n*, when it is not in the same syllable; as, *indignity*, &c.

273. “She is a very amiable *girl*:" pronounce *girl* as if written *gurl*; *gal* is a vulgarism; *gehl* or *gul* is an affectation of which many polite persons are guilty.

274. “He built a large *granary*:" do not pronounce *granary* so as to rhyme with *tannery*. Call the word *grainary*. Both pronunciations, however, are given by scholars.

275. Beware of using *Oh!* and *O* indiscriminately: *Oh!* is used to express the emotion of *pain*, *sorrow*, or *surprise*; as, “*Oh!* the exceeding grace of God.” *O* is used to express *wishing*, *exclamation*, or a direct *address* to a person; as,

“O mother, will the God above  
Forgive my faults like thee?”

276. Be careful to sound distinctly the *r* in such words as *farther*, *martyr*, *charter*, *murder*, &c. Never say, *fah-ther*, *mah-tyr*, *chah-ter* and *muh-der*. On the other hand, avoid *trilling* the *r*, as *mur-er-der*, *r'r'robber*. It is altogether too tragical for common life.

277. “The Duke of Wellington was an *Irishman*, but knew nothing of the *Irish* language:" beware of saying *Ierishman* for *Irishman*, or *Ierish* for *Irish*; a very common mistake, which the “Know-Nothings” are quick to detect.

278. “He did it *unbeknown* to us:" say, *unknown*, &c.

279. “He lives in *affluence*, as he is in *affluent* circumstances:" beware of placing the accent in *affluence* and *affluent* on the syllable *flu* instead of on *af*, a very common error.

280. “If I say, ‘They retreated *back*,’ I use a word that is *superfluous*, as *back* is implied in the syllable *re* in *retreated*:" never place the accent on *flu* in *superfluous*, but always on *per*.

281. "In reading Paley's 'Evidences of Christianity,' I unexpectedly *lit on* the passage I wanted:" say, *met with* the passage, &c.

282. A gentleman having selected a book from the library shelves of the Mechanics' Institute, went to the librarian to have the volume registered under his name, and said, "*I have taken the life of Julius Cæsar.*" "I shall then," responded the librarian, "charge the work to Mr. Brutus!" Be careful how you "take the lives" of distinguished men.

283. "He has a *bayonet* to his gun:" never say *baggonet*. This error is a peculiarity of the Wiltshire dialect, in England. In an old Wiltshire song the following stanza occurs:

"A hornet zet in a holler tree,  
A proper spiteful twoad was he;  
And merrily zung while he did zet,—  
His sting as sharp as a *baggonet*."

284. "Aunt Deborah is down with the *rheumatiz*:" say, *rheumatism*; this is one among the *isms*, though a very unpopular one.

285. "It is *obligatory* upon every honest man to go to the polls to-day:" accent *lig*, and not *ga*.

286. "On the *contrary*:" accent *con*, not *tra*. The old song takes up with a bad pronunciation, for the sake of a good rhyme:

"Mistress Mary,  
Quite *contrary*,  
How does your garden grow?"

287. "That is altogether *above my bend*:" say, *out of my power*.

288. "He has *absquatulated*, and taken the specie with him:" *absconded* is a more classical word.

289. "It's *eenamost* time we had started:" say, *almost*.

290. "*I haven't ary one*:" say, *I have neither*, or, *I haven't either*.

291. "That man is in a *bad box*:" say, *bad predicament*, or *bad situation*.

292. It may be doubted whether to say of a man “that *he barked up the wrong tree*,” is a complimentary or elegant metaphor.

293. “I will retain two-thirds, and give you the *balance*,” say, *remainder*.

294. “I *calculate* to go by steam,” say, “I *expect*.”

295. Avoid using the phrase “*I cave in*,” for “*I give up*.” It savors of slang.

296. Do not say, “*chicken fixings*,” for “*trifles*,” or “*extras*,” connected with dress.

297. “He is a *cute* man,” this is an inelegant abbreviation of *acute*, and employed to mean *smart*. It may, however, be properly applied to Yankees!

298. “He *dickered* with him an hour,” say, “he *bargained*.” This is a word somewhat peculiar to New-York.

299. “*Do don’t*” is a vulgar usage of the Southern States, especially Georgia, for “*do not*.”

300. “He is *done gone*,” say, *ruined*.

301. “We had a *dreadful* fine time,” say, *very*, or *exceedingly*.

302. “It rains, and I want an umbrella *the worst kind*,” say, “*I am greatly in want*,” &c. An umbrella *of the worst kind* would not be likely to answer the best of purposes on a rainy day!

303. “The whole concern *fizzled out*,” say, *proved a failure*.

304. “As soon as I mentioned it to him, he *flared up*,” say, he *became excited*, or *grew violent*.

305. “The choir sang *Old Hundred*,” pronounce *Hundred* as written, and not *Hunderd*.

306. “The message was sent by his *aid-de-camp*,” pronounce as if written *ade-de-kawng*, avoiding, however, as much as possible a twang on the last syllable.

307. “My *beard* is long,” don’t say *baird*.

308. “The blacksmith blows the *bellows*.” pronounce as written, and not *bellus*.

309. “Let me help you to some *catsup*.” avoid saying *ketchup*.

310. “It is new *China ware*.” do not say, *chaney ware*; this latter article exists only in the traditions of old women.

311. “The *combatants* parted in good humor.” accent the first syllable—never the second.

312. “We poled the raft up the *creek*.” pronounce as if written *krik*.

313. “Then spake the *warrior* bold.” pronounce in two syllables, as *war-yur*, not *war-ri-or*.

314. In using the word *venison*, sound the *i*: *venzun* is a common, though not elegant pronunciation.

315. *Tapestry* is divided *tap-es-try* and not *ta-pes-try*.

316. “He is only a *subaltern*.” accent the first syllable of *subaltern*.

317. “The barge is at the *quay*.” pronounce *quay*, *kay*.

318. “The path over the meadow was *queachy*.” this word, meaning *soft* or *boggy*, is now obsolete, and cannot be used with propriety.

319. “He talks *pulpitically*.” this word, which some who copy Chesterfield persist in using, has never by any good authority been admitted into the language.

320. To *peff*, meaning to *cough faintly* (like a sheep), is hardly a useable word.

321. Be careful to distinguish between *pencil*, an instrument for writing, and *pensile*, meaning *hanging down*.

322. To *yank* is a vulgarism, meaning to *twitch powerfully*.

323. Avoid the slang phrase, “*I used to could*.” Say, “*I could formerly*.”

324. “She *takes on* about it greatly.” say, *grieves*.

325. “He *staved off* the case two days longer:” say, he *put off*, or *delayed*.

326. “He made a great *splurge*:” say, he made a *blustering effort*.

327. “I *reckon* it is going to rain:” say, I *think*, or *expect*. *Reckon* applies to *calculation*.

328. “The basket is *pretty large*:” avoid, if possible, the use of the word *pretty* out of its legitimate signification; the language abounds with substitutes more elegant.

329. “She weighs a *plaguy sight*:” say, *a great deal*.

330. “He *made tracks* at sundown:” say, *he left*, or *escaped*.

331. “He was compelled to *fork over the cash*:” say, *to pay over*.

332. “*To flunk out*” is a vulgar expression for *to retire through fear*; the most that can be tolerated is, *to sneak out*.

333. “When last observed, he was *going at full chisel*:” say, *at the top of his speed*.

334. “That bill is a *counterfeit*:” the last syllable is pronounced as if written *fit*, and not *feet*.

335. “I am very much *obliged* to you:” do not say *obleeged*.

336. The following sentence affords an example of three words of similar pronunciation, but different signification: “It is not easy to *pare* a *pear* with a *pair* of scissors.”

337. “The *robber* entered the dwelling, and secretly carried off the silver:” say, *thief*; a *robber* attacks violently, and commits his depredations by main force; a *thief* is one who uses secrecy and deception.

338. “Go and *fetch* me my riding-whip:” say, *bring*. *Fetch* means to *go and bring*; *go and fetch* is repetition.

339. *To leave* and *to quit* are often used as synonymous terms, though improperly; *to leave* implies a design of returning soon—*to quit*, an absence of a long time, or forever; as, in Shakespeare:—

“——the very rats  
Instinctively had *quit* it.”—*Tempest*, i. 2.

“I shall *leave* my house for a month before next Autumn; but I shall not be obliged to *quit* it until after Christmas.”

340. *Mute* and *dumb*. A *dumb* man has not the power to speak; a *mute* man either does not choose, or is not allowed to speak. It is, therefore, more proper to say of a person who can neither hear nor speak, that he is “deaf and *dumb*,” than that he is a “deaf *mute*.”

341. *Strong* and *robust*. These words are frequently misused: a *strong* man is able to bear a heavy burden, but not necessarily for a long time; a *robust* man bears *continual* fatigue with ease; a *strong* man may be active and nimble; while an excess of muscular development, together with a clumsiness of action, exclude these qualities from the *robust* man:—

“*Strong* as a tower in hope, I cry Amen!”  
SHAKESPEARE, *Richard*

II. i. 3.

“For one who, though of drooping mien, had yet  
From nature’s kindness received a frame  
*Robust* as ever rural labor bred.”

WORDSWORTH,  
*Excursion*, VI.

342. “Isaac Newton *invented* the law of gravitation:” say, *discovered*.  
“Galileo *discovered* the telescope:” say, *invented*.

343. To *hear* and to *listen* have each distinct degrees of meaning. To *hear* implies no effort or particular attention. To *listen* implies some eagerness to hear. An old proverb says, “They that *listen* seldom *hear* any good of themselves.”

344. *Ought* and *should* both express obligation, but the latter is not so binding as the former. “Children *ought* to love their parents, and *should* be neat in their appearance.”

345. *Alone* and *only* are often misapplied. “He *only* could do it,” means that no other but himself could do it; “he *alone* could do it,” should mean that he, without the assistance of others, could do it.

346. “Please the pigs.”—(*Old Proverb.*) This is a corruption from “Please the *pyx*.” The *pyx* is the receptacle which contains the consecrated wafer on Romish altars; and the exclamation is equal to “Please God.” This corruption is as curious a one as that of “tawdry” from “’t Audrey,” or “at St. Audrey’s Fair,” famous for the sale of frippery—showy, cheap, and worthless.

347. “The *partridge* is a delightful bird:” do not say *patridge*. Also, do not say *pasley* for *parsley*.

348. “After this, let him hide his *diminished head*:” this common phrase is a poetical quotation from Milton, and is therefore proper to be used even when it does not *literally* express the idea:—

“At whose sight all the stars  
Hide their *diminished heads*.”

349. “That bourne from whence no traveler returns.” How often are precisely these words spoken? They are improperly quoted from Shakespeare, in *Hamlet*, and correctly read as follows:—

“That undiscovered country, from whose bourne  
No traveler returns.”

350. “Bring me my *waistcoat*:” pronounce as if written *waste-coat*, and not *weskut*. It should rhyme, as it did in an old ballad, with “*laced coat*.”

351. “Your *bonnet* to its right use.”—(*Shakespeare*;) never say *bunnet*.

352. “It is not cold enough to wear my *gloves*:” pronounce as if written *gluvs*, and to rhyme with *loves*. In “Fair Rosamond” the following illustrative stanza occurs:—

“He said he had his *gloves* from France:  
The Queen said, ‘That can’t be:  
If you go there for *glove-making*,  
It is without the *g*.’”

353. “*Egad!* what great good luck!” This word is now inelegantly used, except in certain species of poetry, where it is introduced with much effect, as in the following distich:—

“All tragedies, *egad!* to me sound oddly;  
I can no more be serious, than you godly.”

354. “The frigate is now in the Yellow Sea, or *thereabouts:*” say, *thereabout*. This term is a transposed combination of *about there*; there is no such word as *thereabouts*. The same may be said of *hereabouts*, and *whereabouts*.

355. “Whether he will or *no:*” say, *not*. The reason of this correction is clearly seen by supplying what is needed to complete the sense: Whether he will or *will not*.

356. “He looked at it first *lengthways*, then *sideways:*” say, *lengthwise* and *sidewise*. Also, say *otherwise* instead of *otherways*. A nobleman said to his fool, “I am wise, and you are *otherwise*.” “Yes,” replied his jester, “you are wise, and I am *another wise*.”

357. If you are a landlord, beware of incorrectly using such an expression as in the following: A landed proprietor went to a tenant with a view of increasing his rent, and said to him, “Neighbor, I am going to *raise your rent*.” “Thank you, sir,” was the reply, “for I am utterly unable to *raise it myself*.”

358. “Will you *accept* of this slight testimonial?” Omit *of*, which is superfluous, and weakens the sentence.

359. “He convinced his opponent by *dint* of good reasoning:” *dint*, meaning *force* or strength, is an obsolete word, and should not now be employed.

360. “The Danube *empties* into the Black Sea:” say, *flows*; to *empty* means *to make vacant*; no river can properly be called *empty*, until it is entirely dried up.

361. Such words as *bamboozle*, *topsyturvy*, *helterskelter*, *hurlyburly*, and *pellmell* are generally to be avoided. They answer, however, for familiar conversation.

362. Never say *seraphims*, for the plural of *seraph*, but *seraphim*; the same rule holds with *cherubims*. *Cherubs* and *seraphs* are proper plurals, suiting a familiar style of speaking or writing, while *cherubim* and *seraphim* are to be used only in more dignified and solemn discourse.

363. “*There’s* the books you wanted:” say, *there are*: avoid all abbreviations when they lead to a grammatical error, as in the present instance.

364. “This prisoner has, of all the gang, committed *fewer* misdemeanors:” say, *fewest*. We may say *fewer than* all, but we must say *fewest of* all.

365. “I esteem you more than *the others*:” this sentence is equivocal. Does it mean, “I esteem you more than *I esteem the others*,” or, “I esteem you more than *the others esteem you*?”

366. “The most eminent scholars will, on some points, differ *among one another*:” say, *among themselves*.

367. “He, from that moment, doubled his *kindness and caresses of me*:” say, “kindness *for* and caresses of me;” by omitting *caresses* we have, “He doubled his *kindness of me*,” which is not good English.

368. *To differ from* and *to differ with*: to *differ from* a man means to have an opinion different from his; to *differ with* a person signifies a *quarrel* or *rupture*.

369. “He barely escaped having *one or two broken heads*:” a man has but *one* head, let it be broken or whole. Say, “He *once or twice barely escaped* having a broken head.”

370. “Whenever *I fall into that man’s conversation* I am entertained and profited:” say, *fall into conversation with that man*.

371. “The lecturer *spoke to several points*:” say, “spoke *on* several points.” He spoke *to* his audience.

372. “I shall regard your *strictures* only so far as *concerns* my own errors:” say, *concern*; the phrase when filled out should read, “only so far as *they concern* my own errors.”

373. “I found him better than I expected *to have found him*,” say, *to find him*.

374. “I perceived that he was totally blind *with half an eye*,” say, “I perceived, with half an eye, that he was totally blind.” Otherwise, to a man *totally blind* you allot *half an eye*!

375. The word *only* is often wrongly placed in the sentence, and made to express an idea which is not designed to be conveyed. “Not *only* Chinese are superstitious,” implies that others besides the Chinese are superstitious. “Chinese are not *only* superstitious,” implies that in addition to being superstitious, they have some other characteristics. “Chinese not *only* are superstitious,” leaves room for something still further to be implied of the Chinese than superstition, and which is not necessarily the predicate of *are*; as, “Chinese not only are superstitious, but they persecute those who do not put faith in Confucius.”

376. *Not the least* and *nothing less than*, sometimes literally convey just the opposite of what is intended. “He has *not the least* excuse for going,” may mean that he has *a great excuse*, or *none at all*. “He seeks *nothing less than* worldly honor,” may signify that nothing inferior to worldly honor will satisfy his desire; or, on the other hand, it may mean that nothing is less sought by him than worldly honor. Such expressions, therefore, are to be used with caution, else they will mislead.

377. Care should be taken in the use of epithets. For instance, in the sentence, “A *wise and good man* should be respected,” the words *wise* and *good* may properly be applied to the same man; but if the sentence should be altered to read, “An *old and young man*,” it is obvious that both epithets could not relate to the same person.

378. Never say *turkle soup*, for *turtle soup*.

379. The word *long* should not now be employed to signify *many*. An example of this early usage is found in the Fifth Commandment, “that thy days may be *long* upon the land.” The following lines furnish an instance of the verb *to lengthen*, meaning to *make many*:—

“The best of all ways  
To *lengthen* our days,

Is to take a few hours from the night, my lad.”

380. “They returned *back again* to the *same city from* whence they came *forth*.” omit the italicized words, which are redundant and inelegant.

381. “Have you any leisure *upon your hands*?” omit *upon your hands*,—not so much because anything after “leisure” is superfluous, in such a sentence, as because the idea of *having leisure upon your hands* is absurd.

382. “Seven lads were present, and he gave them *all* a book:” say, *gave them each* a book. *All* refers to a number of persons or things taken *collectively*, as *one body*; *each* refers to *every individual*, separately considered.

383. “Lend me your *umberell*.” say, *umbrella*. The former pronunciation, however, is allowed by *poetic license*, as in the following, adapted from Thomas Moore:—

“Oh, ever thus from childhood’s hour,  
Has chilling fate upon me fell!  
There always comes a soakin’ shower  
When I hain’t got an *umbrell*.”

384. We lately met a grammarian, who had just made a tour through the mines, conjugating, or, rather, cogitating thus: “Positive, *mine*; comparative *miner*; superlative, *minus*!”

385. “Put not thy secret into the mouth of the *Bosphorus*, for it will betray it to the ears of the Black Sea.”—(*Oriental Proverb*.) Pronounce *Bosphorus* as if written *Bosforus*, and not *Bos-porous*.

386. Be careful to use the hyphen (-) correctly: it joins compound words, and words broken by the ending of a line. The use of the hyphen will appear more clearly from the following example: “*many colored wings*” means *many wings which are colored*; but “*many-colored wings*” means “wings of *many colors*.”

387. “I am *afraid* it will rain.” say, *I fear*. *Afraid* expresses terror; *fear* may mean only *anxiety*.

388. Never say *o-fences* for *offences*; *pison* for *poison*; *co-lection* for *collection*; *voiolent* for *violent*; *kivver* for *cover*; *afeard* for *afraid*; *debbuty* for *deputy*. The last three examples are very common.

389. “It is a mere *cipher*:” never spell *cipher* with a *y*.

390. “I was *necessitated* to do it:” a poor expression, and often made worse by *necessiated* being used: say, I was *obliged*, or *compelled*, to do it.

391. “Gibbon wrote the *Rise* and Fall of the Roman Empire:” pronounce *Rise*, the noun, so as to rhyme with *price*; *Rise*, the verb, rhymes with *prize*.

392. “He joined his *regiment* last week:” never say, *ridgiment* for *regiment*.

393. “He bought a *gimlet*:” never spell the last word *gimblet*, as many do.

394. “He is a supporter of the *Government*:” beware of omitting the *n* in the second syllable of *Government*—a very common practice.

395. “Received this day *of* Mr. Brown ten dollars:” say, “Received this day *from*,” &c.

396. “Of whatever you *get*, endeavor to save something; and with all your *getting*, *get* wisdom:” carefully avoid saying *git* for *get*, and *gitting* for *getting*.

397. “So intent was he on the song he was *singing*, while he stood by the fire, that he did not perceive that his clothes were *singeing*.” Verbs ending with a *single e*, omit the *e* when the termination *ing* is added, as, *give*, *giving*; in *singeing*, however, the *e* must be retained, to prevent its being confounded with *singing*. The *e* must also be retained in *dyeing*, to distinguish it from *dying*.

398. The following sentences may be studied: “The *dyer dyes* daily, yet he *dies* not.” “The *miner minds* the *minor mines*.” “It is not *meet* to *mete* out such *meat*.” “He performed a great *feat* with his *feet* at the *fête*.” (*Fête* is pronounced *fate*.)

399. “*Lower* the sails, as the sky begins to *lower*:” pronounce *low* in the *former* so as to rhyme with *mow*, and *low* in the *latter* so as to rhyme with *cow*.

400. “There was a great *row* on Monday, in Tryon Row:” pronounce the former *row* so as to rhyme with *cow*—the latter *row*, so as to rhyme with *mo*.

401. “His *surname* is Clifford:” never spell the *sur* in “surname” *sir*, which shows an ignorance of its true derivation, which is from the Latin.

402. “The buildings are so old that they pay *almost no rent* now:” *scarcely any rent*, is better.

403. “His *mamma* sent him to a preparatory school:” *mamma* is often written with one *m* only, which is not, as may at first be supposed, in imitation of the French *maman*, but in sheer ignorance.

404. Active verbs often take a neuter sense; as, “*The house is building*:” here, *is building* is used in a neuter signification, because it has no object after it. By this rule are explained such sentences as, “*Application is wanting*;” “*The Grammar is printing*,” &c.

405. “He *attackted* me without the slightest provocation:” say, *attacked*.

406. “I called on him every day in the week *successfully*:” very common, but incorrect; say, *successively*.

407. “I fear I shall *discommode* you:” it is better to say, *incommode*.

408. “I can do it *equally as well as* he:” leave out *equally*, which is superfluous.

409. “We could not forbear *from* doing it:” leave out *from*, which is unnecessary; or say, *refrain from*.

410. “He was totally dependent *of* his father:” say, dependent *on* his father.

411. “They accused him *for* neglecting his duty:” say, *of* neglecting, &c.

412. “They have a great resemblance *with* each other:” say, *to* each other.

413. “I entirely dissent *with* him:” say, *from* him.

414. “He was made much *on* at the Springs:” say, made much *of*, &c.

415. "He is a man *on* whom you can confide:" say, *in* whom, &c.

416. "He was obliged to *fly* the country:" say, *flee* the country. A very common mistake.

417. "The snuffers *wants* mending:" say, *want* mending. No one would say, "My *pantaloons* is ripped."

418. "His conduct admits *of* no apology:" omit *of*, which is quite unnecessary.

419. "A *gent* has been here inquiring for you:" a detestable, but very common expression; say, a *gentleman* has been, &c. Oliver Wendell Holmes hits off this liberty with language, in the following happy couplet:  
—

"The things called *pants*, in certain documents,  
Were never made for *gentlemen*, but *gents*."

420. "That was *all along of* you:" say, "That was *all your fault*."

421. "You have no *call* to be angry with me:" say, no *occasion*, &c.

422. "Too free an *indulgence* in luxuries *enervate* and *injure* the system:" say, *enervates* and *injures*, &c. The plural, *luxuries*, standing directly before the verb, (which should be *enervates*, in the singular,) deceives the ear. Errors of this kind are very common, though a moment's thought would correct them. The verb must agree with its subject in person and in number; if the *noun* is in the singular, the *verb* that belongs to it must also be in the singular.

423. "A father divided a portion of his property *among* his two children, and the remainder he distributed *between* the poor:" say, *between* his two children, and *among* the poor. *Between* is applicable to two only, *among* to three or more.

424. "Every child should obey *their* parents:" say, *his* parents. The pronoun must agree with the noun in number, &c.

425. "He is a person *who* I respect greatly:" say, *whom*. "Be careful *who* you trust:" *whom* you trust.

426. “Let me consider *of* this matter.” “The culprit dreaded to enter *in* the prison.” “The laborers were not allowed to want *for* anything.” Leave out the *italicized* words—the sense being complete without them.

427. *Cupola* is often pronounced *cupalo*; *foliage*, *foilage*; *future*, *futur*; *nature*, *natur*: all of which errors should be carefully avoided.

428. “‘Ow ’appens it that *Henglishmen* so *hoften* misplace their *haitches*?” It is a cockneyism; and if you have fallen into the habit, it will require perhaps more perseverance than you imagine, to correct it.

429. Do you say *wagabond* or *vagabond*, *winegar* or *vinegar*, *wery* or *very*, *valking* or *walking*, *vatchman* or *watchman*? It is a local custom, but if you have any taint of it, don’t sing “*Villikins and his Dinah*.”

430. *Providence*, *confidence*, and similar words, are often pronounced *Providunce*, *confidunce*, &c., substituting *unce* for *ence*. So also, words ending in *ance*, as *maintenance*, *sustenance*, *SURVEILLance*, are pronounced falsely *maintenunce*, *sustenunce*, &c.

431. *Coming*, *going*, *according*, &c., are often pronounced without the final *g*: speak them distinctly, and pronounce difficult words with *de-lib-er-a-tion*.

432. If you are a Yankee, you should (though, as a general thing, you *will not*) take special pains with your vowel sounds, that they be not formed through the nasal cavities. Don’t say *heow*, *ceow*, *confeound*, for *how*, *cow*, &c.

433. If you are a Western man, you are liable to give your vowel sounds too great breadth. You should not say *bar* for *bear*, *hum* for *home*, *dawlar* for *dollar*; and it is better to avoid using such expressions as *I reckon*, *I guess*, *I calculate*, too frequently.

434. “I am going *a fishing*.” be bold enough to be one among the foremost to break away from the bad habit of saying *a fishing*, *a talking*, *a courting*, &c. This custom, however, should be retained in quoting proverbs and wise sayings; these are better in proportion as they are older; for example: “*Who goes a-borrowing, goes a-sorrowing*.” The quaintness would be destroyed by saying simply *borrowing* and *sorrowing*.

435. Some people add a superfluous preposition at the end of a sentence —“More than you think *for*.” This is awkward.

436. “Then think *on* the friend who once welcomed it too,” &c. &c.: say, *of*.

437. *Thou* and *thee* are no longer used in spelling or writing, except by some of The Friends; but proverbial citations, originally expressed in that form, lose much of their beauty and force by alteration; as, “If thou seest thy house in flames, approach and warm thyself by it.” How greatly would a change of person tame the spirit of this fine proverb!

438. “By the street of ‘*By-and-By*,’ one arrives at the house of ‘*Never*.’” Do not say, *By’mby*.

439. Be careful to observe the *two plurals* of the following nouns:

| Singular.        | First Plural.                                | Second Plural.                                 |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Brother</i> , | <i>Brothers</i> (of the same parents),       | <i>Brethren</i> (of the same society).         |
| <i>Die</i> ,     | <i>Dies</i> (for coining),                   | <i>Dice</i> (for gaming).                      |
| <i>Index</i> ,   | <i>Indexes</i> (tables of contents),         | <i>Indices</i> (signs in algebra).             |
| <i>Pea</i> ,     | <i>Peas</i> (referring to a limited number), | <i>Pease</i> (referring to the whole species). |
| <i>Penny</i> ,   | <i>Pennies</i> (coins),                      | <i>Pence</i> (the value).                      |
| <i>Cow</i> ,     | <i>Cows</i> (a herd of cattle),              | <i>Kine</i> (the species).                     |
| <i>Sow</i> ,     | <i>Sows</i> (a litter),                      | <i>Swine</i> (the species).                    |
| <i>Genius</i> ,  | <i>Geniuses</i> (men of genius),             | <i>Genii</i> (imaginary spirits).              |

440. Different shades of meaning may be expressed by slight variations in the position of the important words in a sentence. For example, “*The Paradise Lost of Milton*,” is not exactly the same in import as, “*Milton’s Paradise Lost*,” in the former, attention is called to the author—in the latter, to the poem.

441. In uniting the plural of *one*, *two*, *three*, do not use the apostrophe ['] as *one's*, *two's*, *three's*. Good writers never conform to the latter mode. Wordsworth, who was remarkably particular, not only in the choice of his words but in their orthography, wrote:

“The sun has long been set,  
The stars are out by *twos and threes*;  
The little birds are piping yet  
Among the bushes and the trees.”

442. “*How's yourself*, this morning?” an exceedingly common, but very objectionable expression: say, “*How are you*;” &c.

443. “Wanted, two apprentices, who will be treated as *one* of the family:” great practical difficulty would be found in realizing such treatment! Say, “as *members* of the family.”

444. The following lines afford an instance of the ingenious uses to which the English language may be put:

“You *sigh* for a *cipher*, but I *sigh* for you;  
Oh, *sigh* for no *cipher*, but oh, *sigh* for me;  
Oh, let not my *sigh* for a *cipher* go,  
But give *sigh* for *sigh*, for I *sigh* for you so!”

The above is more briefly expressed in the following manner:

“U O a O, but I O u,  
Oh, O no O, but oh, O me;  
Oh, let not my O a O go,  
But give O O I O u so!”

445. Sometimes *but* is incorrectly substituted for *that*: as, “I have no doubt *but* he will be here to-night.” Sometimes for the conjunction *if*, as, “I shouldn’t wonder *but* that was the case.” And sometimes *two* conjunctions are used instead of one, as, “*If that* I have offended him,” “*After that* he had seen the parties,” &c. All this is very awkward and should be avoided.

446. “My hands are *chopped*,” say, *chapped*.

447. “This will serve as a *preventative*,” say, *preventive*.

448. “A *nishe* young man,” “What *makesh* you laugh?” “If he *offendsh* you, don’t speak to him,” “*Ash* you please,” “Not *jush* yet,” “We always *passh* your house in going to call on *Missh Yatesh*.” This is decided, unmitigated *cockneyism*, having its parallel in nothing except the broken English of the sons of Abraham, and to adopt it in conversation is certainly “not speaking like a Christian.”

449. Never say, “Cut it in *half*,” for this you cannot do unless you could *annihilate one* half. You may “cut it in two,” or “cut it in halves,” or “cut it through,” or “divide it,” but no human ability will enable you *to cut it in half*.

451. *To lay and to lie*.—*To lay* is an active or transitive verb, and must always have an object, expressed or understood. *To lie* (not meaning *to tell a falsehood*) is a neuter or intransitive, and therefore does not admit of an object. The only real difficulty arises from the fact, that the past tense of “lie,” when used without an auxiliary, is the same as the present of “lay.” But a little attention will obviate this. Nothing can be more erroneous than to say, “I shall go and lay down.” The question which naturally arises in the mind of the discriminating hearer is, “*What* are you going to lay down—money, carpets, plans, or what?” for, as a transitive verb is used, an object is wanted to complete the sense. The speaker means, that he himself is going *to lie down*. “My brother *lays* ill of a fever,” should be, “My brother *lies*,” &c.

| VERB<br>ACTIVE.                     |   |           | VERB<br>NEUTER.                     |   |            |
|-------------------------------------|---|-----------|-------------------------------------|---|------------|
| <i>To lay.</i><br>Present<br>Tense. |   |           | <i>To lie.</i><br>Present<br>Tense. |   |            |
| I lay                               |   |           | I lie                               |   |            |
| Thou layest                         |   |           | Thou liest                          |   | down,      |
| He lays                             | } | money,    | He lies                             | } | too long,  |
| We lay                              |   | carpets,  | We lie                              |   | on a sofa, |
| You lay                             |   | plans,    | You lie                             |   | —any       |
| They lay                            |   | —         | They lie                            |   | where.     |
|                                     |   | anything. |                                     |   |            |

| Imperfect Tense. |   |                  | Imperfect Tense. |   |               |
|------------------|---|------------------|------------------|---|---------------|
| I laid           |   |                  | I lay            |   |               |
| Thou laidest     |   |                  | Thou layest      |   |               |
| He laid          | } | money,           | He lays          | } | down,         |
| We laid          |   | carpets,         | We lay           |   | too long,     |
| You laid         |   | plans,           | You lay          |   | on a sofa,    |
| They laid        |   | —                | They lay         |   | —any          |
|                  |   | <i>anything.</i> |                  |   | <i>where.</i> |

Present Participle, Laying.

Perfect Participle, Laid.

Present Participle, Lying.

Perfect Participle, Lain.

452. Many people have an odd way of saying, “I expect,” when they mean only “I think,” or “I conclude;” as, “I expect my brother went to Richmond to-day,” “I expect those books were sent to Paris last year.” *Expect* can relate only to *future* time, and must be followed by a future tense, or a verb in the infinitive mood; as, “I expect my brother *will go* to Richmond to-day,” “I expect *to find* those books were sent to Paris last year.”

453. “A *summer’s* morning,” should be, A *summer* morning.

454. The vulgar speaker uses adjectives instead of adverbs, and says, “This letter is written *shocking*,” the genteel speaker uses adverbs instead of adjectives, and says, “This writing looks *shockingly*.”

455. “*Nobody else* but him,” should be, *Nobody* but him.

456. “That *ain’t* just,” should be, That *is not* just.

457. “He was killed *by* a cannon-ball,” should be, He was killed *with* a cannon-ball. He was killed *by* the cannoneer.

458. “A *new pair* of gloves,” should be, A *pair of new* gloves.

459. “*Before* I do that, I must *first* be paid,” should be, Before I do that, I must be paid.

460. A grammatical play upon the word *THAT*:

“Now *that* is a word which may often be joined,  
For *that that* may be doubled is clear to the mind;  
And *that that that* is right, is as plain to the view,  
As *that that that that* we use is rightly used too;  
And *that that that that that* line has in it, is right—  
In accordance with grammar, is plain in our sight.”

461. “He will go *from thence* to-morrow.” The preposition “from” is included in these adverbs, therefore it becomes tautology in sense when prefixed to them.

462. “Equally as well,” is a very common expression, and a very incorrect one; the adverb of comparison, “as,” has no right in the sentence. “Equally well,” “Equally high,” “Equally dear,” should be the construction; and if a complement be necessary in the phrase, it should be preceded by the preposition “with,” as, “The wall was equally high with the former one,” “The goods at Smith’s are equally dear with those sold at the shop next door,” &c. “Equally the same” is tautology.

463. Some persons talk of “*continuing on*,” in what other direction would it be possible to *continue*?

464. “The satin measured twelve yards before I cut this piece *off of* it.” “The fruit was gathered *off of* that tree.” Omit *of*; or, omitting *off of*, insert *from*.

465. “He left his horse, and got *on to* a stage-coach,” “He jumped *on to* the floor,” “She laid it *on to* a dish,” “I threw it *on to* the fire.” Why use two prepositions where one would be quite as explicit, and far more elegant? Nobody would think of saying, “He came to New-York, *for* to go to the exhibition.”

466. “No other resource *but* this was allowed him:” say, “No other resource *than* this,” &c.

467. "I don't know but *what* I shall go to White Plains to-morrow:" say, "I don't know but *that*," &c.

468. "One of those houses *were* sold last week," "Each of the daughters *are* to have a separate share," "Every tree in those plantations *have* been injured by the storm," "Either of the children *are* at liberty to claim it." Here it will be perceived that the pronouns "one," "each," "every," "either," are the true nominatives to the verbs; but the intervening noun in the plural number, in each sentence, deludes the ear; and the speaker, without reflection, renders the verb in the plural instead of the singular number.

469. "Many still die annually *from* the plague:" say, *of* the plague.

470. "He spoke *contemptibly* of him," should be, He spoke *contemptuously* of him.

471. "Was you?" should be, *Were* you?

472. "This is the more *perfect* of the two:" say, More *complete*. *Perfect* rarely admits comparison.

473. Avoid all slang and vulgar words and phrases, as, *Anyhow*, *Bating*, *Bran new*, *To blow up*, *Bother*, *Cut*, *Currying favor*, *Fork out*, *Half an eye*, *I am up to you*, *Kick up*, *Scrape*, *The Scratch*, *Walk into*.

474. "Go *over* the bridge," should be, Go *across* the bridge.

475. "*I was some distance from home*," should be, I was *at* some distance from home.

476. "Is Mr. Smith *in*?" should be, Is Mr. Smith *within*?

477. "It is *above* a month since," should be, It is *more* than a month since.

478. "Vegetables were *plenty*," should be, Vegetables were *plentiful*.

479. "We both were *very disappointed*." This is an incomplete expression: say, *very much*, or *very greatly*. No one would think of saying, "We both were *very pleased*."

480. "It is I who *is* to receive the appointment:" say, who *am* to receive; *who* is in the first person, and the verb of which it is the subject must be in

the same.

481. Never say *biscake*, for *biscuit*.

482. “Passengers are *not requested* to let down the chains, before the boat is fastened to the bridge.” [From a printed regulation on one of the New-York and Brooklyn ferry-boats.] The reading should be, “Passengers *are requested not to let down* the chains.”

483. “How will you *swap* jack-knives?” *swap*, although it is a word familiarly used in connection with “jack-knives,” is a term that cannot lay the least claim to elegance. Use some other of the many mercantile expressions to which trade has given rise.

484. “He’s put his nose to the *grin-stone* at an early age.” [A remark usually made by old ladies, suggested by the first marriage among their grandsons.] Say, *grind-stone*. A *grin-stone* implies a stone that “grins,” whereas, especially in this instance, the “nose” fulfills that office.

485. The importance of punctuating a written sentence is often neglected. Space does not permit the giving of rules on this subject, in this book. Business correspondence is generally blemished by many omissions of this character; for example, “Messrs G Longman & Co have recd a note from the Cor Sec Nat Shipwreck Soc informing them of the loss of one of their vessels off the N E Coast of S A at 8 P M on the 20 of Jan.” A clergyman, standing in his pulpit, was once handed a slip of paper, to be read in the hearing of the congregation, which was intended to convey the following notice: “A man going to sea, his wife desires the prayers of the church.” But the sentence was improperly punctuated, and he read, “A man going to see his wife, desires the prayers of the church!”

486. “The knave thereupon commenced rifling his *friend’s* (as he called him) *pocket*.” say, “The knave commenced rifling the *pocket of his friend*, as he facetiously called him.” The possessive case, and the word that governs it, must not be separated by an intervening clause.

487. “I owe *thee* a heavy debt of gratitude, and *you* will not permit me to repay it.” say, either “I owe *you*,” &c., preserving “and *you* will” in the second clause; or, “I owe *thee*,” and altering “and *you* will” into “and *thou wilt*.”

488. “Every lancer and every rifleman *were at their post:*” say, *was at his post.*

489. “I can lift as many pounds *as he has:*” add *lifted.*

490. Do not use *to*, the sign of the infinitive mood, for the infinitive itself. “I have not written to him, and I am not likely *to*,” should read, “I am not likely *to write to him.*”

491. The word *agree* is sometimes followed by the wrong preposition. We should say, agree *with* a person—*to* a proposition—*upon* a thing among ourselves.

492. We should say *compare with*, in respect of quality—*compare to*, for the sake of illustration.

493. We should say copy *after* a person—*copy from* a thing.

494. *Between* is properly applied only to two objects; *among*, to three or more. “A father divided a portion of his property *between* his two sons; the rest he distributed *among* the poor.”

495. *In* should not be used for *into*, after verbs denoting entrance. “Come *in* my parlor,” should read, “Come *into* my parlor.”

496. “We confide *in*, and have respect *for*, the good.” Such a form of expression is strained and awkward. It is better to say, “We confide *in* the good, and have respect for *them*,” or, “We *trust* and *respect* the good.”

497. “This veil of flesh parts the visible and the invisible world:” say, “parts the visible *from* the invisible.” It certainly is not meant that the veil of flesh *parts* (or *divides*) each of these worlds.

498. “Every leaf, every twig, every blade, every drop of water, *teem* with life:” say, *teems.*

499. “Dr. Prideaux used to relate that when he brought the manuscript of his Connection of the Old and the New Testaments to the publisher, *he told him* it was a dry subject, and that the printing could not be safely ventured upon unless he could enliven the work with a little humor.” The sense alone, and not the *sentence*, indicates to whom *he* and *him* respectively refer; such a

form of expression is faulty, because it may lead to a violation of *perspicuity*, which is one of the most essential qualities of a good style.

500. The last direction which this little book will give, on the subject with which it has been occupied, is one that long ago was given in the greatest of books—"Let your conversation be as it becometh the Gospel of Christ." If obedience to this injunction may not guard him who heeds it against the commission of such mistakes as are numbered in this catalogue, it will not fail to lead him out of the way of errors more grievous and solemn.

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